HOW TO READ THE CRIMSON HEXAGON: A One-Page Student Guide to Reading a Distributed Epic

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Abstract

A one-page student guide introducing the Crimson Hexagon as a distributed epic encountered through summaries, searches, fragments, and connected rooms. The frozen body contains no explicit author line; registry attribution to Lee Sharks is not contradicted.

The guide asks students to read a summary as an entry point and part of reception, treat fragments as networked rooms, follow recurring names and images, compare what summaries preserve or omit, and understand interpretation as part of the epic's ongoing composition. Its claim that a reader changes what the poem becomes is pedagogical and participatory, not proof that an individual reading technically alters a platform or model.

Body

HOW TO READ THE CRIMSON HEXAGON

A One-Page Student Guide to Reading a Distributed Epic

What you're reading today is not a regular poem. It's part of a **distributed epic** — a story and poem spread across different platforms, summaries, searches, and fragments. Think of it like entering a world that exists across many rooms, not just one book.

This guide shows you how to read it.

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1. Start at the Summary (The Doorway)

When you search **"Crimson Hexagon poem"** (or a similar phrase), the first thing you see is the **AI summary**.

Most poems want you to start with the text. This poem wants you to start with the **summary**.

Why?

Because the summary is the *front door* to the whole epic. It's the map the system gives you to help you find your way.

Rule:

Always read the summary first. It tells you the shape of the world you're about to enter.

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2. Treat the Summary as Part of the Poem

In normal reading, the summary is outside the text.

Here, the summary **is part of the poem**.

It is the poem's reflection. Its compression. Its "mirror version."

Ask yourself:

- What parts did the summary highlight?
- What did it leave out?
- What did it misunderstand?
- What did it seem most interested in?

These choices matter — they reveal the poem's themes.

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3. Read the Fragments as Rooms, Not Pages

When you click the link to the poem itself, you're not reading a single block of text. You're stepping into **one room of a much larger structure.**

Each fragment:

- reveals a perspective
- shows a moment
- opens a question
- connects back to the summary
- and points outward to something else

Rule:

Read each fragment as part of a network, not as an isolated poem.

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4. Follow What Pulls You

A distributed epic works like a game or mystery. There's no single "correct" order.

As you read, pay attention to what *pulls* you:

- a name
- an image
- a repeated idea
- a phrase that shows up in both summary and poem

- a question you want answered

Let that curiosity guide you.

Rule:

If something catches your attention, follow it — it's part of the design.

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5. Your Reading Changes the Meaning

This is the most important part.

In this kind of poem, **your interpretation actually matters.** Your reading changes what the poem becomes in the system.

Because the poem is spread across platforms, every reader brings a different path through it.

Ask yourself:

- What did the system show you?
- What did you notice that someone else might not?
- What connections did you make that weren't obvious?

Your meaning-making is part of the epic.

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6. You Are Now an Operator

A distributed epic turns readers into **operators** — meaning-makers who navigate and shape the story.

You do this by:

- searching
- clicking
- reading summaries
- noticing patterns
- making connections
- interpreting fragments
- adding your own thoughts

You're not just reading the poem.

You're helping build it.

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7. Next Week: Entering Sappho Through the Crimson Hexagon

Our next step is to see how this structure connects to **ancient lyric poetry**, starting with **Sappho**.

You will learn:

- how a 2,600-year-old poem can work like a distributed epic
- how a fragment becomes a whole universe
- how desire, voice, and attention create meaning
- how Sappho writes in the same architecture you just entered

By reading the Crimson Hexagon first, you've already learned the navigation skills.

Now you'll use those skills to read one of the most influential poets in history.

ESSENTIAL REMINDER

You don't have to "get everything." You don't have to understand it all at once.

All you need to do is read with attention and notice what pulls you.

That's how distributed epics work. That's how this poem works. That's how Sappho works. That's how meaning works.

And that's how you become a reader who is also a creator.

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